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EVERY DAY IS 'TECH DAY' IN THE FREE PRESS

TECH TODAY

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WWW.FREEP.COM

NETWATCH

WHAT EVERYBODY ELSE IS DOING ONLINE

Top momentum-building Google search terms.
www.google.com
1. napster
2. lyrics
3. grutella
4. flowers
5. greeting cards

Top momentum-losing Google search terms
1. XFL
2. Annabel Chong
3. Survivor
4. Eminem
5. groundhog day

Week ending Feb. 14

Top 5 musicians whose lyrics are searched for via Ask Jeeves:
www.ask.com
1. Shaggy
2. Eminem
3. Nelly
4. Backstreet Boys
5. Limp Bizkit

Top 5 musicians whose pictures are searched for via Ask Jeeves:
1. Britney Spears
2. Jennifer Lopez
3. Christina Aguilera
4. Justin Timberlake
5. Blink-182

Note: Of the 70,000 questions asked about Britney Spears, only 3 percent were about her music. The other 97 percent were requests for pictures of her.
Month of January

Online usage update
Internet penetration has reached 60 percent in the United States, with more than 168 million people having Web access from either the home or the workplace in January. Here's how, on average, we spend our time online (combined figures for home and work Internet usage):
Number of sessions per month: 28
Number of sites visited: 19
Time spent per month: 15:03:24
Time per session: 0:31:36
Time per page: 0:00:58
Nielsen//NetRatings, month of January

TODAY'S PICKS & CLICKS

BABY SHOWER HOUR Join April 2001 Pregnancy Circle Community Leaders for a special Parent Soup online baby shower. Lavish all those expectant moms due in April with virtual and real gifts. 4 p.m. **www.ivillage.com**

BODY IMAGE AFTER SURGERY The physical and emotional effects of surgery can be difficult. Learn ways to feel better about your body, share your experiences and find support from others who understand. 8 p.m. **www.thriveonline.oxygen.com**

WE ARE FAMILY Gay, lesbian and bisexual teens, 13-17, get together in a safe atmosphere with a host. 8 p.m.-2 a.m. **www.talkcity.com/calendar**

THANK GOD I'M A COUNTRY BOY Billy Gilman sang his way out of kindergarten to opening gigs with the likes of Jo Dee Messina. He recently received a Grammy nomination for best male country vocal performance. Check out this audio Webcast recorded Nov. 12. 9 p.m. **www.hob.com**

PRETTY WOMAN, SEXY MAN Brad Pitt and Julia Roberts. She's favored to win the Oscar for best actress. He's been called the sexiest man alive. Now they're costarring in "The Mexican" and doing their first chat. For AOL subscribers only. **Keyword: AOL Live.**

TECH WEEK

LOCAL EVENTS AND CLASSES

⑲ **MONDAY**
- Defog Computer User Group monthly meeting, 7-9:30 p.m., 6701 Harrison, Room 5, Garden City. **http://defog.org** or call 313-2784707.

⑳ **TUESDAY**
- OPC Computer Club meetings at the Rochester Older Persons Activity Center, 312 Woodward St., Rochester. Monthly meeting, genealogy Internet forum, evening club, etc. Glen Drellishak talks about using TechTV as a source of information. **www.geocities.com/Heartland/Village/1904** or call 248-656-1403.
- Ann Arbor IT Zone Hi-Tech Tuesday: Understanding Copyright Creation and Owners, a Technology Context. 5-7:30 p.m. at Ann Arbor IT Zone Launch Pad, 330 Liberty, downtown Ann Arbor. Presenter is lawyer Michael Huget. $25 for nonmembers, $5 for students, free for members. **www.annarboritzone.org** or call 734-6238286.

㉑ **WEDNESDAY**
- OPC Computer Club Special Tutoring/Web site workshop, 1-4 p.m. at the Rochester Older Persons Activity Center, 312 Woodward St., Rochester. Work on OPC Web sites. **www.geocities.com/Heartland/Village/1904** or call 248-656-1403.
- Genealogy on the Web, 6:30-8 p.m., Southfield Library, 26000 Evergreen, Marcotte Room, Southfield. $5 for Southfield-Lathrup residents, $10 for nonresidents. **http://www.metronet.lib.mi.us/SFLD/libcal.html** or call 248-948-0470.

㉒ **THURSDAY**
- Creative Control Center seminar, 1:30-3:30 p.m. at 26899 Northwestern Hwy., Suite 209, Southfield. Learn how to have greater control over your work using Creative Control Center tools. Free. **http://seminars.apple.com** or call 800-895-4853.

㉓ **FRIDAY**
- Basic Web Searching, 2-3 p.m., Detroit Public Library Internet Training Lab, 5201 Woodward, Detroit. **www.detroit.lib.mi.us** or 313-833-4790 to register.
- Investment Information on the World Wide Web, 2-3 p.m., Detroit Public Library Internet Training Lab, 5201 Woodward, Detroit. **www.detroit.lib.mi.us** or 313-833-4790 to register.
- Introduction to Microsoft PowerPoint, 3:30-5 p.m., Detroit Public Library Internet Training Lab, 5201 Woodward, Detroit. **www.detroit.lib.mi.us** or 313-833-4790 to register.
- Introduction to the Internet, 10-11:30 a.m., Macomb County Library, 16480 Hall Road (M59 & Garfield Road), Clinton Twp. Free. Call 810286-6660.
- Introduction to the Online Library, 2-3:30 p.m., Macomb County Library, 16480 Hall Road (M59 & Garfield Road), Clinton Twp. Learn how to access the Macomb County Library's Web site, use the electronic catalog, make free printouts of magazine articles and use other online databases. Free. Call 810-286-6660.
- Defog Computer User Group, Another Saturday Night Chat, 8:30-9:30 p.m. **http://defog.org/chat**

SPECIAL
BLACK HISTORY MONTH
EDITION

WEB GUIDE>>

NET COMMUNITIES

Where it's @

Afro Americ@ ★★★★
www.afroam.org

From its online art gallery to its slavery exhibition, this site keeps you clicking. The best parts are its authoritative features. They handle subjects from the 1960s-70s Black Panther Party to World War II's Tuskegee Airmen with insight. This is a great place to find current news as well as historical perspectives on events. There's a Kids Zone, too, offering games, brain teasers, myths and fables as well as a Discover Africa area. A bookmark for young and old.
By Howard Davy

"March Break," by Thomas Stockett, featured in afroam.org's art gallery >>

NET COMMUNITIES

Here and There

LittleAfrica ★★★★
www.littleafrica.com

LittleAfrica is a smorgasbord of information for blacks who want to feast on specialized investing, shopping, traveling, small business, health and career development information.

If you're interested in black history, check out the list of nearly 200 black inventors and their inventions. Need to laugh? Check out Mama's Boyz comics. The site also offers a list of about 500 cultural resources, including black-owned banks, investment companies and organizations.

The site, created in spring 1997, has a cultural connection that dates to the early 1900s, when there was an affluent all-black community of more than 600 businesses in north Tulsa, Okla., known as Black Wall Street or Little Africa. The community was destroyed in June 1921 during a race riot. This site pays tribute to that entrepreneurial community, which later was rebuilt. Site creators say they also want to help black entrepreneurs and consumers benefit from the Internet.
By Tara Ransom

>> A snapshot from the photo album of the NBS Youth team on nbs.org. SEE SPORTS LISTINGS

WEB GUIDE is written by the staff of the Free Press. Reviews range from one to four stars and are not connected to advertising. To recommend a site, send a note to techtoday@freepress.com

Yahoo! for you

NetNoir ★★★
www.netnoir.com

As one of the black pioneers on the Web, NetNoir set the standard for today's black sites. Sometimes called the black Yahoo!, NetNoir partnered with many sites before the dot-com boom. It provides features, chat rooms, e-mail services and up-to-date news reports of special interest to blacks. The site is sluggish at times but is the Woodward Avenue for the black Web.
By Howard Davy

I dream a world

BlackPlanet ★★★
www.blackplanet.com

All the friends you could ask for are online at BlackPlanet. As a meet-and-greet portal geared toward blacks, BlackPlanet is a hot spot for the bunny slipper crowd as well as the corporate shark. Members can post pictures as well as chat with others online. The site gets congested at times and requires a certain level of patience.

But memberships are free and worth signing up for.
By Howard Davy

SPORTS

Get a lift

National Brotherhood of Skiers ★★★
www.nbs.org

Much of this site, run by the nation's largest club of black skiers, is similar to what you'd find in any decent skiing publication: etiquette on the slopes, how to buy the best ski boots, which accessories you really need and which you can forget about.

But go deeper. There's a page of links to more than 50 black ski groups, including the Jim Dandy Ski Club in Detroit, the first such club in the nation. (For Detroiters, the club history, which is also posted on the site, is a fascinating microcosm of the city's history for the last 43 years.) There are also dozens of club-sponsored events, some close to home, Vermont and Pennsylvania, and others as far afield as New Zealand.
By David Lyman

HEALTH

Sisterly advice

BlackWomensHealth ★★★
www.blackwomenshealth.com

Sisters, if you're looking for a little emotional, spiritual and physical healing, this site has a variety of advice and information that will feed your soul.

BlackWomensHealth.com is dedicated to the health and wellness of today's black women. Article topics range from strength training to how to make sure your retirement finances are in order. Use the site to locate a doctor, explore contraception options or find out about dietary supplements and tips for diabetics.

Most informative are the topics along the left side of the screen. They make it easy to jump straight to information on specific topics.
By Sheryl Kennedy

READING

Up-and-comers

Mosaic magazine ★★★
www.mosaicbooks.com/maginfo.htm

It's hard to keep a literary magazine going, so one that has lasted since 1997, as Bronx, N.Y.-based Mosaic has, is doing something right.

Mosaic succeeds by focusing on young black and Hispanic writers with real literary promise, such as Zadie Smith and Paul Beatty, though it does sometimes review and interview lighter, more commercial writers, such as E. Lynn Harris. The nonfiction reviews cover liberal-to-moderate history, journalism and sociology books.

Be aware that the Web site posts only a few stories from the current issue; the goal is to sell print copies. A four-issue subscription is $12. Order online or by mail. Look for the five previous issues at **www.saltbc.com/writers/mosaic.htm**. The magazine requests a $2 donation for each download of a back issue.

One quibble: The current issue's Web page favors virtually unreadable small yellow type on a black background. Maybe that's a ploy to sell print subscriptions.
By Marta Salij

Black and read all over

The Black Press ★★★
www.pbs.org/blackpress

A quick history of the black press has been brought online by PBS. Visitors to the Black Press: Soldiers Without Swords can peek into a history that might not be known by most of today's budding journalists. There is an interactive make-your-own newspaper (You'll need the Shockwave plug-in on your PC.) as well as many interesting facts. The site, although full of information, is subordinate to the PBS movie, which you can buy ($195) through a referred site that concentrates on educational videos about black life: **www.newsreel.org**.
By Howard Davy

SHOPPING

Brainy browsing

African Treasures ★★★
www.africantreasures.net

If you want to learn about African crafts as well as buy them, this is the place. There's plenty of text among the pictures, and it's written in a personable, lively tone.

Not only does it explain the history and traditional use of African baskets, pottery and musical instruments but it also offers modern-day updates. You could use the snake basket to transport your small pet to the vet, the site helpfully suggests, or place the covered baskets from Ghana in your kids' rooms for storage.

Much of the merchandise appears to be from Morocco. There are intricately patterned Moroccan baskets, mirrors and pottery, including pretty vases and large, covered ashtrays.

You can't order online, only by phone, fax or e-mail. So take notes while you shop. You'll need to supply a description and a price for each object you buy.
By Holly Hanson

Art and effort

A Piece of Africa ★★
www.apieceofafrica.co.za

Undoubtedly, there's a lot of lovely merchandise at this e-store, which offers handmade decorative items from Mozambique, Angola, Zambia, South Africa, Tanzania and Zaire. But it's hard to tell because of the site's odd organization and tiny pictures.

The merchandise is split into five categories, listed along the left side of the screen. The Carvings area includes wooden puzzles, warthog-teeth key rings and bottle openers, and clay and Masai masks. In the Fabrics section, there are tablecloths, body wraps, cushions and wall hangings, in what appear to be lively prints and vibrant colors.

The Ornaments selection ranges from Zulu spears to beaded mugs, necklaces and jug nets. Carefully crafted dolls come in sizes ranging from refrigerator magnet to door stopper. Plates, bowls, bottles and trays are made of woven grass.

Under Instruments, there are tribal drums made of wood and animal hide, as well as keyboards and rattles. The Leather section offers animal-hide rugs, ostrich belts and antelope key rings.

There is much here to savor and enjoy, but the shopping experience is slow and frustrating because of the postagestamp-size pictures.
By Holly Hanson

TRAVEL

Wandering soul

Soul of America ★★★★
www.soulofamerica.com

SoulofAmerica hits on just about everything that black travelers look for. The links give fabulous insight on where to go, how to get there, who's having a special in that city and how much it's all going to cost. All you have to know is that you want to take a trip. Click on various black-themed cruises that occur over the course of the year. Or find out about black towns, black innkeepers and black resorts and spas all over the world. You can even find specials on travel to Africa.

It's updated only weekly, but the info is great for planning.
By Kelley L. Carter

USEFUL

One moment in time

Moments in Black History ★★★
www.momentsinblackhistory.com

This site chronicles each day of the year with factoids about what piece of black history was made. You can't advance months here, but you can see what happened the day before or the day after, and often the historical tidbits are little-known facts, such as the death of Lorimer Douglas, a banker and adviser to Presidents Dwight D. Eisenhower and John F. Kennedy.
By Kelley L. Carter

USEFUL

Smart start

African American Odyssey ★★★★
http://memory.loc.gov/ammem/aaohtml/aohome.html

For finding historical information about black people online, check out the U.S. Library of Congress. This site takes an in-depth look at the black journey in this country. Pictures, newspaper clippings and historical documents help weave a tale of struggles and triumphs. From slavery through the civil rights movement, this site offers documents you can't find at commercial Web sites. The Library of Congress also offers links for more information on the struggle of black Americans and makes for an ideal starting point for teachers and history buffs.
By Howard Davy

BELOW: An 1882 poster for a production of "Uncle Tom's Cabin"

FREE PRESS SITE OF THE WEEK>>

THESE SPECIAL-EDITION SITE OF THE WEEK RECOMMENDATIONS ARE FROM STUDENTS AT **MALCOLM X ACADEMY IN DETROIT.**

Detroiter Rosa Parks, mother of the civil rights movement

Black history, literature, culture live in Web sites

Timbooktu
www.timbooktu.com

This site is a place where African-American literature is put on display. While searching this Web site, I learned there are many African-American literary artists. People who might have a heart for Afro-centric literature can read a lot of it on this Web site. I recommend this site to anyone who likes literature.
By Louis Blessman, eighth grade

Black Facts Online
www.blackfacts.com

This is an online database of nothing but facts on the history of African Americans. Just about anything you can think of is available on this site. This is a good place to access to help create games and other educational materials. If nothing else, this site will be useful to dispel myths about contributions of African Americans in this country.
By Johnathon Ray, seventh grade

Black History Pages
www.blackhistorypages.com

This site offers a variety of information highlighting the roots of culture of African Americans. It is equipped with various links to other interactive sites. The page even has its own search engine. Many aspects of the African-American experience are covered, including politics, entertainment, sports and religion. This is a good starting point for learning more about an ever-advancing culture.
By Gabriel Doss, seventh grade

Everything Black
www.everythingblack.com

This is an interactive media site that features information on many aspects of African-American life. Topics like arts and humanities, business, education and more are outlined with current, insightful commentary from many of the country's leading voices. There is also a search engine designed to help you find everything black on the Web.
By Cedric Stanton, eighth grade

Read the new TechToday page weekdays in the Free Press, too! >**MONDAYS:** Local technology >**TUESDAYS:** Goods and gear >**WEDNESDAYS:** Help, how-to >**THURSDAYS:** Digital living >**FRIDAYS:** Games

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